

European Union

Foreign Policy

A Historical Overview

Jake Reed

Based on: Federiga Bindi, Chapter Overview



The Early Foundations (1950s)

- 1950 – Schuman Plan → European Coal and Steel Community (ECSC) formed
- German rearmament dilemma post-WWII leads to the Plevin Plan (1950)
- European Defense Community (EDC) proposed: supranational military structure
- EDC signed May 27, 1952 — ratified by Germany, Benelux; rejected by France (1954)
- Anthony Eden's alternative → Germany joins NATO & Western European Union (WEU)
- European defense becomes a transatlantic issue for decades

EEC Treaty & External Competences (1957)

Treaty Provisions

- Common External Tariff (CET)
- Commercial policy toward third states
- Association of overseas territories
- European Development Fund (EDF)
- Legal personality for the Community

Commission's Role

- Submit proposals for common commercial policy
- Negotiate agreements with third countries
- Protective measures under art. 115
- Negotiate tariff agreements (Council approval)
- Leading actor in external trade matters

The De Gaulle Era & EPC Origins (1958–1969)

- De Gaulle's vision: 'European Europe' but 'Europe des États' — sovereign nations cooperating
- 1959 – Regular EEC foreign minister meetings approved (precursor to CAGRE)
- 1961 – First EU summit: precursor to the European Council
- Fouchet Committee proposed common foreign & defense policy — ultimately rejected
- De Gaulle vetoed UK membership (1963 & 1967) — France withdraws from NATO (1966)
- 1969 – Pompidou's 'Triptique': Completion, Deepening, Enlargement at The Hague Summit

European Political Cooperation (1970–1973)

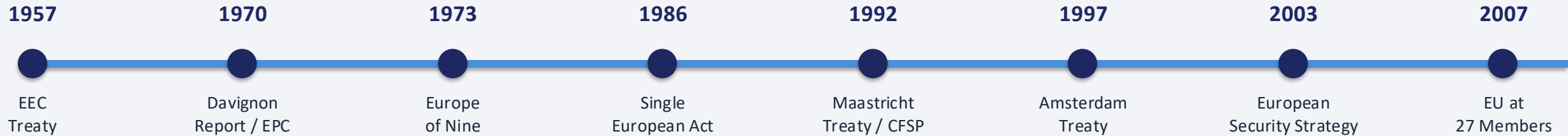
Davignon Report (1970)

- Regular meetings of EEC foreign ministers
- Eventual heads of state summits
- Regular consultations on foreign policy
- European Commission to be consulted
- Parliament–ministers meetings every 6 months

Copenhagen Report (1973)

- Ministers of foreign affairs meet 4× a year
- Political Committee prepares ministerial meetings
- Created 'Group of Correspondents' & COREU telex
- Subcommittees: CSCE, Middle East, Mediterranean, Asia
- Declaration on European Identity (Dec. 1973)

Key Milestones in EU Foreign Policy



The Maastricht Treaty & CFSP (1992)

- EPC replaced by Common Foreign and Security Policy (CFSP) — 2nd pillar of the EU
- CFSP objectives: safeguard common values, strengthen security, promote democracy
- Member states to act in 'spirit of loyalty and mutual solidarity'
- European Council defines general guidelines; Council implements (unanimity)
- Commission given joint right of initiative; European Parliament to be consulted
- WEU finally permitted to address defense questions — potential path to common defense
- Three-pillar structure: CFSP (intergovernmental) + JHA + supranational EC pillar

The EU's Five Major Enlargements

Rounds & New Members

- 1973 – UK, Denmark, Ireland (Europe of Nine)
- 1981 – Greece (Europe of Ten)
- 1986 – Spain & Portugal (Europe of Twelve)
- 1995 – Austria, Finland, Sweden (EU-15)
- 2004/2007 – 12 CEECs + Cyprus & Malta (EU-27)

Foreign Policy Impact

- UK brought Falklands/Rhodesia solidarity
- Spain/Portugal opened Latin America relations
- CEECs: Copenhagen criteria & accession strategy
- Balkans given 'potential candidate' status (2000)
- ENP created for neighboring non-candidate states

Amsterdam Treaty & ESDP (1997–1999)

- Amsterdam Treaty: High Representative for CFSP appointed (Javier Solana, 1999)
- New troika: HR + EU Presidency foreign minister + European Commission representative
- Policy Planning and Early Warning Unit ('Policy Unit') established
- Saint-Malo Declaration (1998): EU needs 'capacity for autonomous action' with credible military forces
- 1999 Helsinki European Council: EU to deploy 60,000 troops within 60 days by 2003
- European Security Strategy (2003): multilateralism, key threats identified — first EU security doctrine
- European Defense Agency created July 2004

Key Themes & Conclusions

Integration vs. Sovereignty

The tension between supranational EU institutions and member-state national interests has defined European foreign policy from the outset.

Incremental Institutionalization

From EPC (1970) → CFSP (1992) → ESDP (1999): each treaty added new instruments and actors to EU foreign policy.

Transatlantic Friction & Cooperation

The EU repeatedly clashed with the U.S. on the Middle East, sanctions, and defense, while remaining embedded in NATO.

Enlargement as Foreign Policy

The EU's most successful foreign policy tool has been the accession process — democratizing and stabilizing neighboring states.